

Security is about restricting access, whether to a physical object, a location, information, an application, or a particular feature of an application. Talking about computers and networks, there is no fool-proof way of protecting a system till you disconnect your network card, switch off your system and make sure that no one has access to it. But, of course, this is not possible if you need to use the system!

A combination of protections is necessary to secure a system. At a minimum, we recommend the following protective measures be taken by all users who connect to the Internet.

1. Verifying identities using passwords
2. Determining what information a user has permission to see or what software a user has permission to use (that is, determining their access permissions)
3. Using anti-virus and anti-spyware software and Firewalls
4. Encrypting data

10.1 Restricting System Access

10.1.1 User Accounts

Securing Windows XP starts with limiting who can access your system. To set new usernames and passwords, you need to be logged in as an administrator, which is the default login after you've installed the OS.

Click Start > Control Panel > User Accounts. Select 'Create a new account'. In the next screen, type in the new username you want to create and click 'Next'. The resulting screen allows you to 'Pick an account type', which is either 'Computer Administrator' or 'Limited'. Setting the new user to be a Computer Administrator allows him to make system-wide changes, which means giving complete control of the system to him. Setting the new user to 'Limited' restricts him to changing his password, viewing files he has created, and viewing files in the 'Shared Documents' folder.